

useful for Media Center PCs, WMV can be considered a version of the MPEG-4 codec design.

RealVideo: Developed by RealNetworks, a popular codec (.ram file extension) technology a few years ago, now fading in importance for a variety of reasons.

Flash Video: Gaining popularity of late, the Macromedia Flash Video file format (FLV) is becoming a standard on many Web sites. To play back files, a Macromedia Flash Video player is embedded into the Web page. You may need to also get the Flash plug-in for your browser.

Finding out what codec is missing can be a frustrating process if done manually. Thankfully, there are codec information software tools that will do the job for you. Select the multimedia file that is not playing from within the codec information tool, and it will inform you what codec is required to play the file correctly. Some of the tools also give you direct links to download the missing codecs! Take your pick from some of the popular commercial and freeware tools listed below.

VideoInspector (www.kcsoftwares.com/index.php?vtb): This gives direct download links to missing codecs after analysing the file format. Can analyse most file formats such as AVI, MPEG, etc.

Gspot (www.headbands.com/gspot/): Even though it has some features missing that you can find in others, Gspot is a useful tool. It was a pioneer in troubleshooting video applications.

MediaInfo (<http://mediainfo.sourceforge.net/en>): An open source alternative to GSpot.

AVICodec (<http://avicodec.duby.info>): Another useful codec information tool.